CHAPTER 40

CRUEL SPORT

24 June 2014

ENGLAND vs SRI LANKA, 2nd Test, *Headingley – Day 5*

Sri Lanka 257 & 457; England 365 & 249

Sri Lanka won by 100 runs

England 2nd innings: **J Anderson c Herath b Eranga 0 (55 balls)**

It has somehow come to this. Two Test matches, both travelling the entire stretch of five days. Sri Lanka survived at Lord's against all the odds, batting to save the Test with their last wicket intact, the final ball from Stuart Broad edged and falling agonisingly short of Chris Jordan at slip. Now, it is our turn to survive. Moeen Ali, new to Test cricket, has batted fluently, expressively and with courage to reach 108 not out. His rearguard effort, somehow languid and expressive, has nearly taken us there, but as we fight to draw the game with only one wicket in hand, I am left to face the last over myself.

I hate batting. I always have. I resent that cricket throws me into these situations where, batting 11 for England, I am often left in the tensest position and with the entire fate of a series depending on some sort of act of God. It's always me that's there when things have gone wrong. Always me there to shake hands when we have been beaten, the final punch always landing on me. Now, I have to face six balls from Shaminda Eranga. All I need to do is not get out, save the series, stop Sri Lanka from a first series win in England that they are desperate for. I keep telling myself: just watch the ball. Stay in line with it. Let it hit you if it needs to. If it hurts, that's